

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SEYCHELLES

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the islands and waters of Seychelles, and one campaign against a foreign-backed base near a pristine atoll showed that a public that mobilises, and a parliament that will not ratify, can stop a large project a government had already signed. On a remote island called Assumption, some eleven hundred kilometres from the main island of Mahé and close to Aldabra — one of the largest atolls on Earth, a World Heritage Site, home to the world's largest population of giant tortoises — a foreign power was to build a military base under a signed twenty-year agreement, funded and part-run from abroad. It looked settled. But Seychellois citizens, environmental organisations, and much of the public opposed it — out of genuine fear for the pristine environment near Aldabra, and out of concern for the country's sovereignty. They protested. The concerns reached the World Heritage authorities. And, decisively, the opposition that held a majority in the National Assembly refused to ratify the agreement, so the government could not carry it through. The base was not built; the agreement was, in the end, declared dead; and Seychelles chose to build its own, smaller facility instead. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a project is stopped. The agreement had been signed at the highest level and was backed by a powerful foreign partner willing to fund the base entirely; on paper it looked done. But the plan ran into a nation that prized the pristine waters near Aldabra and guarded its sovereignty, and the opposition took two forms that reinforced one another. Citizens and environmental organisations raised genuine alarm about the proximity of the works to a World Heritage atoll, and their concern was serious enough that the World Heritage authorities themselves took note of it. And a broad public unease about a foreign military presence, and about a deal made with little openness, brought people into the streets. Crucially, the political opposition held a majority in the National Assembly, and an agreement of this kind needed the Assembly's ratification; the opposition made plain it would not ratify, and so the government, unable to command the votes, could not present it. Over the following period the deal was revised, then left unrepresented, and at length declared dead — and the nation resolved to build a smaller facility of its own instead.

The Seychelles story teaches two things about stopping destructive projects here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected public, the documentation, the coalition, the international attention, and the democratic process — pressed together. The second is distinctly Seychellois, and it stopped a base. **A public that mobilises to protect a pristine, protected place, and a parliament whose approval a project needs and cannot get, can together stop a large project a government has signed.** That power — the defence of a protected place, the public mobilisation, the international attention, and above all the democratic and parliamentary process — is the Seychelles' distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made the Assumption campaign work as a model, and what a later community can copy, was the way it joined a mobilised public and a threatened treasure to the one lever a small parliamentary democracy makes unusually potent: the legislature's power to withhold its approval. A great many projects and agreements of consequence require the National Assembly's ratification or approval, and a parliament that refuses can halt a project a government has already signed, however powerful its backers. The public mobilisation and the threat to a World Heritage place supplied the pressure and the cause; the international eye supplied the weight; and the parliament supplied the decisive act of refusal. Defend the place, mobilise the public, draw the world's eye, and turn the parliament: that is the template — with the honest caution that the decisive lever needs a parliament willing to refuse, which in a small democracy is itself decided at the ballot box.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The decisive lever — a **parliament that would not ratify** — was available because the opposition held a majority in the Assembly; where a government controls the legislature, that lever is weaker, and the ballot box becomes part of the fight. The opposition was of **mixed motives** — genuine environmental protection of a pristine atoll, and also national sovereignty and geopolitics — and honesty requires naming both. And the outcome had **nuances**: the base was blocked, but the agreement lingered in diplomatic language, and a foreign presence did not vanish overnight. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of public mobilisation, the protection of a pristine place, and the democratic process — and the electoral dependence, the mixed motives, and the nuanced outcome that qualify them. It is worth being candid about these from the start, because they shape how such a fight must be run. The parliamentary lever was decisive at Assumption precisely because the opposition held the Assembly; had the government commanded a majority, the ratification might have passed, and the campaign would have had to fight on other ground — the courts, the international bodies, the next election — and might well have lost. The motives, too, were genuinely mixed: for many the driving concern was the

pristine environment near Aldabra, for others the nation's sovereignty and its place amid the rivalries of larger powers, and an honest campaign acknowledges both rather than pretending one was the whole. And the outcome was not a single clean cancellation but a gradual shelving: the deal was revised, left unpresented, and only in time declared dead, while a foreign surveillance presence remained on the island. A community that understands all this fights more wisely — it works the parliament where it can, the ballot box where it must, and the environmental and international levers throughout — and it judges its success by whether the destructive project is stopped, not by whether every trace of the matter disappears at once.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a project the government has signed and assume "the deal is done and nothing can be done," and never mobilise the public, never rouse the environmental concern, never turn the democratic and parliamentary process against it. They generate private worry without a public claim. The gap between a project stopped and one built is rarely apathy — Seychellois showed a public will protest and a parliament will refuse. It is method: knowing how to mobilise the public, protect the place, draw the international eye, and use the democratic process.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Seychellois system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a base, a resort, a reclamation, or another destructive project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the project, the approval it needs, and the leverage)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build the evidence and the case for the place)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (build the broad public coalition)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL & DEMOCRATIC (the approvals, the parliament, and the international bodies)
|
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a national and international cause)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the parliamentary argument and the public case at once; the coalition grows; a protest or an international concern is a headline and a headline builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project's approval withheld, a parliament unmoved, the project stopped. The Assumption campaign did exactly this — it mobilised the public, protected the place, drew the international eye, and turned the parliament against the deal.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. The Seychelles' give communities a distinctive set:

- **The pristine, protected place.** A **World Heritage site or protected area** at risk rouses a nation and the world, as Aldabra did.
- **The democratic and parliamentary process.** A project that needs **parliament's approval or ratification** can be stopped by a parliament that refuses, as the Assumption agreement was. This is the lever that most distinguishes a Seychellois fight of this kind, and it is worth understanding why it is so potent in a small parliamentary democracy. A government may sign an agreement or launch a project, but where the law requires the National Assembly to ratify or approve it, the project cannot proceed against a parliament that says no. That gives a campaign a single, decisive point of leverage — the ratification or approval vote — at which even a powerfully backed, already-signed project can be halted outright. And because the Assembly is small and its members answerable to a small electorate, a mobilised public can reach and move it directly. A campaign that establishes early that a project needs the Assembly's assent, and then concentrates its force on persuading the members to withhold it, is aiming at the point where a Seychellois project is often most vulnerable — as the opponents of the Assumption base aimed, and prevailed.
- **Public mobilisation.** A **small nation's public**, mobilised and protesting, is felt directly, as it was over Assumption.
- **International attention.** The **World Heritage and international bodies** bring a global eye, as UNESCO's concern over Aldabra did.
- **The electoral argument.** In a small democracy, **elections and the make-up of parliament** decide whether the decisive lever is available, as the opposition's majority did.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers deliver a clean, guaranteed win. The parliamentary lever depended on an **opposition majority**; the opposition had **mixed motives**; and the outcome had **nuances**, with a foreign presence not vanishing at once. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real,

distinctive tools the Seychelles offers — the pristine place, the public, the international eye, and the democratic process — as the opponents of the Assumption base used them, while facing the electoral dependence and the nuances honestly.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the project — or the leverage — is weakest. And map the approvals, because in the Seychelles a project that needs parliament's assent is vulnerable at exactly that point.

The Levels of Decision

A Seychellois project like this runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government. The **government** signs and drives the big projects and the agreements — but it can be stopped when it needs an approval it cannot get, as the government could not carry the Assumption agreement.

The parliament. The **National Assembly**, distinctively, must **ratify or approve** many agreements and projects — and a parliament that refuses can stop a project outright, as the Assembly's refusal stopped the base. It is worth grasping why this makes the parliament the pivot of so many Seychellois fights of consequence. In a parliamentary system, the executive may negotiate and sign, but the legislature's ratification is what gives many agreements and major projects legal force; withhold it, and the project has no ground to stand on. This is a cleaner and more decisive lever than the slow attrition of objections and challenges, because a single refusal can end the matter. But it comes with a condition a campaign must face squarely: the parliament must be willing to refuse, and that willingness depends on its composition, which the electorate decides. A campaign should therefore map early whether a project needs the Assembly's assent, count the members likely to support or oppose, and — where the numbers are not there — recognise that part of the fight belongs at the next election.

The approvals and the environment. The **permits and the environmental approvals** are open to objection, especially where a **protected place** is at risk, as Aldabra's protection concentrated the opposition.

The international bodies. The **World Heritage and international bodies** bring a global eye to a threat to a protected place, as UNESCO's concern did over Aldabra.

The public and the coalition. The **public, the environmental organisations, and the coalition** are the force that mobilises, protects the place, draws the international eye, and turns the parliament — the force that stopped a base.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a government decision or a signed agreement, through **approvals, ratification, and permits**, toward construction — with the **public, the parliament, and the international bodies** able to protest, refuse, and scrutinise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in**, and the ratification or approval stage is the distinctive Seychellois door. The distinctive Seychellois levers are the **pristine protected place**, the **public**, the **international eye**, and the **democratic and parliamentary process**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **whether it needs parliament's approval or ratification** that can be withheld, **whether it threatens a protected place** that rouses the nation and the world, and **whether the public can be mobilised**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Approval, and the Place

Behind a project stand a proponent — the government, a foreign or private developer — and the approvals it needs. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly in the Seychelles — **whether the project needs an approval or ratification that can be withheld, whether it threatens a pristine or protected place** that draws national and international concern, **whether the public can be mobilised**, and **what the project does to the environment and the country**. Two questions unlock most Seychellois fights of this kind: **Does it need parliament's approval, and can that be withheld?** and **Does it threaten a protected place that rouses the public and the world?** The democratic process and the protected place are, together, the heart of most such Seychellois campaigns. These two reinforce one another in a way particular to the Seychellois fight: the threat to a protected place supplies the cause that mobilises the public and draws the world's eye, and the democratic process supplies the mechanism — the parliament's power to refuse — through which that mobilised feeling becomes a decision that stops the project. A campaign with a threatened treasure but no parliamentary lever may rouse the nation and still see the project built; one that has the parliamentary lever but no cause to move the public and the members has little to bring to the vote. Joined together — a pristine place whose peril

rouses the nation and the world, and a parliament that can be moved to refuse the approval the project needs — they can stop even a signed project, as they stopped the Assumption base. And a mobilised public and an international eye are what carry the cause from the streets to the chamber.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **National Assembly**, whose approval a project may need; the **courts**; the **World Heritage and international bodies**; the **environmental organisations** — including those that manage the protected places; the **free press**; and the **public**, whose mobilisation a small nation feels directly. In the Seychelles, the **pristine protected place, the public, the international eye, and the democratic and parliamentary process** are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project that threatens a protected place, faces a mobilised public and an international eye, and needs a parliamentary approval it cannot get rarely proceeds — as the Assumption base did not.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Seychellois and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **needs a parliamentary approval or ratification** that can be withheld, whether it **threatens a pristine or protected place** that rouses the nation and the world, whether the **public can be mobilised**, and whether the **make-up of parliament** puts the decisive lever within reach. Where the project needs parliament's assent and threatens a protected place, the Seychelles' levers are real, as Assumption shows; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the parliamentary lever depended on an opposition majority, that the motives were mixed, and that the outcome had nuances.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	weeks-months	low	Basis for every other step
Defending the protected place	45-70%	months	low	A national and international cause
Public mobilisation	45-70%	weeks-months	low	A small nation's public felt directly
The parliamentary process	50-75%	months	low	An approval or ratification withheld
International attention	40-65%	months	low	A global eye on a protected place
Objecting in the approval process	35-60%	months	low	Objections on the record; delay
Media & public pressure	45-70%	ongoing	low	A national and international cause
All steps (needs approval, protected place)	45-70%	months	low	Approval withheld; project stopped
All steps (no approval needed, govt majority)	25-50%	months	low	Delay; the record; the case made

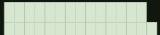
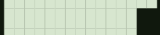
Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and the Seychelles' real strengths are distinctive — the **protected place**, the **public**, the **international eye**, and the **democratic and parliamentary process**. Its constraints are specific: the parliamentary lever needs a **parliament that will refuse**; the motives may be **mixed**; and the outcome may be **nuanced**.

A note on cost: mobilising the public, defending the place, drawing the international eye, and working the parliament cost mainly time, unity, and the help of organisations, and the Seychelles' small size, active civil society, and world-renowned protected places supply real strength. But the expenditure that most changes outcomes is the breadth of the public mobilisation and the resolve of the parliament, exactly what the opponents of the Assumption base brought to bear.

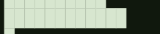
Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (approval withheld, project stopped, place protected)

NEEDS PARLIAMENT + THREATENS PROTECTED PLACE + PUBLIC MOBILISED:

All steps combined:		45-70%
Parliamentary process:		50-75%
Defending the place:		45-70%
Public mobilisation:		45-70%
Single step:		5-75%

NO APPROVAL NEEDED / GOVT MAJORITY -- no ratification to withhold:

All steps combined:		25-50%
Protest + press + delay:		the levers that remain
The record / the case made:		more achievable than a full stop
Single step:		5-50%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in the Seychelles are **the democratic and parliamentary process, the protected place, and public mobilisation**, amplified by the international eye.

Assumption shows the ceiling — and its honest shape: a threatened World Heritage atoll, a mobilised public, an international eye, and a parliament that would not ratify stopped a foreign base — but the parliamentary lever depended on an opposition majority, the motives were mixed, and the outcome was nuanced. Most Seychellois fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the democratic process and the protected place are powerful levers — decisive where a project needs parliament's assent and threatens a protected place, weaker where no approval can be withheld, where the realistic win is delay, a record, and the case made. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a campaign against a project that threatens a genuinely protected place and needs a parliamentary approval an opposition-minded Assembly can withhold is in the stronger band and can aim to stop the project outright, as at Assumption; a campaign against a project that needs no such approval, or faces a parliament the government controls, is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, a record, the international eye, and the case made — while working to shape the parliament at the next election. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where the place is protected and the parliament reachable, and realistic where the ground is harder.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The democratic and parliamentary process and the protected place** — the Seychelles' most distinctive levers; a parliament that refuses, and a pristine place that rouses the nation, as at Assumption.
2. **Public mobilisation** — the protests and the public feeling a small nation registers directly, as over Assumption.
3. **The international attention** — the World Heritage and international eye on a protected place, as UNESCO's over Aldabra.
4. **The environmental organisations** — the organisations and the managers of the protected places, whose expertise and standing count.
5. **The media** — the national and international cause that sustains the pressure.

What Seychellois Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **A protected place rouses the nation and the world** — the threat near Aldabra made it a national and international cause. **A mobilised public is felt directly** — a small nation's protests reach its leaders. **A parliament that refuses stops a project** — the Assembly's refusal to ratify was decisive. **The international eye adds weight** — UNESCO's concern mattered. **But the lever needs a willing parliament, and motives may be mixed** — the opposition majority made it possible, and both environment and sovereignty drove it. The through-line: **defend the protected place; mobilise the public; draw the international eye; turn the democratic and parliamentary process against it — because in the Seychelles a mobilised public and a parliament that will not ratify can stop even a signed project.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact project and approval that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which in the Seychelles is often the parliamentary approval and the protected place. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the base that needs the Assembly's ratification and threatens our World Heritage atoll" is a campaign — the kind that stopped Assumption. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Does it threaten a pristine or protected place? This is the first Seychellois question of this kind. Does the project **threaten a World Heritage site, a protected area, or a pristine place** whose loss would rouse the nation and the world, as the base near Aldabra did. Assess this honestly at the outset, because in the Seychelles the value and the

protected status of a threatened place are what most rouse the nation and the world, and so what most shape what is achievable. Where a site is genuinely pristine or protected — a World Heritage listing, a nature reserve, an atoll of world renown — its peril can be made a national and international cause, and a mobilised public and an alerted world can be brought to bear. Where a site is more ordinary, that depth of feeling is harder to summon. A community should therefore establish, first and with the listings and the science, just how protected and how treasured its threatened place truly is, for that value is the fuel of the mobilisation the fight will require.

2. Does it need parliament's approval or ratification? Does the project — the agreement, the deal — need the **National Assembly's approval or ratification** that can be **withheld**, as the Assumption agreement did. This is the question that most shapes the strategy of a Seychellois fight of this kind, and it should be settled early. If the project rests on an agreement or a step that by law requires the National Assembly's ratification or approval, the campaign has a single decisive lever to aim at, and should concentrate much of its force there. If it does not — if the government can proceed on its own authority — that lever is absent, and the campaign must lean harder on the environmental objection, the courts, the international bodies, and the pressure of publicity. Establishing exactly which approvals a project needs, and which of them require the Assembly, is therefore among the first tasks, for on it the shape of the whole campaign depends.

3. Can the public be mobilised? Can the **public** be **mobilised and brought to protest**, as it was over Assumption, because a small nation's public is felt directly.

4. Does it draw international attention? Does the threat to a protected place draw the **World Heritage and international bodies**, as UNESCO's concern over Aldabra was drawn.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which proponent, government, and interest are behind it, who profits; and which parliament, courts, international bodies, organisations, press, and public can be engaged.

A Worked Example

Suppose a large project is planned that threatens a protected place and needs the Assembly's approval.

Working the five questions: does it **threaten a protected place**? Does it **need parliament's approval**? Can the **public be mobilised**? Does it **draw the international eye**? And the deciders are the government and the proponent, with the parliament, the international bodies, and the public as the pressure points.

Within weeks you have moved from "the deal is signed" to a target list: defend the protected place; mobilise the public; draw the international eye; and turn the parliament against the approval. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how a base was stopped. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a sense that the deal was signed and nothing could be done into a set of concrete, workable tasks — defend the protected place, mobilise the public, draw the international eye, turn the parliament against the approval — each tied to a specific lever that the Seychelles genuinely provides. That reframing, from resignation before a signed agreement to a plan built on the place, the public, and the parliament, is the difference the questions make, and the first two — whether it threatens a protected place, and whether it needs a parliamentary approval that can be withheld — together often decide how strong a hand the campaign holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. The parliament, a court, an international body, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and in the Seychelles, the threat to a protected place and the need for an approval that can be withheld are precisely what a campaign turns into pressure, so document them well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Approval, and the Process

Get the documents the project rests on. Obtain the **project details, the agreement, and the approvals it needs** — and establish, crucially, **whether it needs parliament's ratification or approval** that can be withheld, as the Assumption agreement did. Scrutinise the process: was it transparent, or was the agreement kept from the public, as the Assumption pacts were leaked before they were seen? Establish the approval it needs, because that is the point of maximum leverage.

Layer 2: The Place and the Harm

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **protected place** at the centre. Record the **value** — the World Heritage status, the protected habitats, the species (the giant tortoises, the seabirds), the pristineness — as Aldabra's value is world-renowned. Record the **harm** the project would do — to the protected place, its species, its waters, its integrity. Photograph and map it. Record **testimony** from citizens and the organisations that manage the place, and gather **expert evidence** on the environment. This is the case that rouses the public, the parliament, and the world. The value of the place, in particular, deserves to be documented not as vague praise but as a concrete, world-recognised fact, because on a small nation whose protected places are a source of national pride and international renown it is among the most powerful things a campaign can establish. Set out, with the listings, the science, and the images, exactly what the place is — its World Heritage status, the species it shelters, the habitats it holds, the pristineness that makes it irreplaceable — so that the threat to it is shown to be not a local inconvenience but a loss the nation and the world would feel. At Assumption the defenders could point to the proximity of the works to one of the world's great atolls, a World Heritage treasure of giant tortoises and untouched reef; a community should build the same concrete, recognised case for the value of its own threatened place, for that value is what turns a project into a national and international cause.

Layer 3: The Place, the Approval, and the Public Interest

Finally, document the case. Does the project **threaten a protected place** whose loss the nation and the world would feel? Does it **need an approval that can be withheld**? And does the **public interest** — the environment, the sovereignty, the transparency — weigh against it? Each is a separate ground — for the parliament, the courts, the international bodies, and the campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Seychellois fights of this kind, because here a project is revealed to threaten a protected place, to need an approval a parliament can withhold, and to run against the public interest — exactly the case that stopped Assumption, whose threat to a World Heritage atoll and need for a ratification the Assembly would not give turned the nation, the world, and the parliament against it. Assembling all three grounds together — the threat to a protected place, the approval a parliament can withhold, and the weight of the public interest — is what gives a Seychellois case its force, because each serves a different front and they reinforce one another: the threat to the place rouses the public and the world, the parliamentary approval supplies the decisive point of refusal, and the public interest gives the members and the courts the ground on which to act. A campaign that establishes only one may leave the project a way through; one that establishes all three, as the opponents of Assumption did, can turn the public, the world, and the parliament against the project at once — which is how a signed, foreign-backed base beside a World Heritage atoll was in the end stopped.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Seychellois cases of this kind, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the threat to the place, the approval that can be withheld, and the weight of the public interest.

The Project, the Approval, and the Paper Trail

- **The project and the agreement** — the project, its scale, and any agreement behind it.
- **The approval it needs** — whether it requires the Assembly's ratification or approval.
- **The process** — whether it was transparent, consulted, and lawful, or hidden.
- **The protected status** — the World Heritage listing, the protected-area designation.
- **The proponent and the beneficiaries** — who is behind it, who profits, and on what terms.

How to Get Them

The project, the agreement, the approvals, and the protected status are matters of record, obtainable from the government, the Assembly's proceedings, and the international listings — and where an agreement is kept from the public, its emergence, even by leak, becomes itself part of the story, as it did over Assumption. The openness of the process, in particular, is worth documenting carefully, because a project pursued in secrecy is doubly vulnerable: the harm it would do and the way it was hidden are two distinct grievances, each of which moves the public and the parliament. Establish, as precisely as you can, whether the public and the Assembly were properly informed and consulted, or whether the agreement was made and advanced with little openness and came to light only through disclosure or leak; either way, the record of how the process was conducted is evidence in its own right. At Assumption, that the pacts surfaced publicly before they were openly presented sharpened the sense that the nation was being asked to accept something it had not been allowed to see. Lean on **allies**: the Seychelles' environmental organisations, the managers of its protected places, and its parliamentarians, who know the approvals, the protected areas, and the international frameworks. Move promptly: establishing the threat to the place and the approval it needs early, and mobilising the public, lets you turn the parliament

before the project advances, as the opponents of Assumption did.

The Ground Evidence

- **The value of the place** — the World Heritage status, the species, the pristineness.
- **The harm** — what the project would do to the protected place and its integrity.
- **The approval that can be withheld** — the ratification or approval the project needs.
- **The public interest** — the environment, the sovereignty, the transparency.
- **Testimony and expertise** — from citizens, the place's managers, and environmental experts.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the agreement, the approvals, the objections, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom — the parliament, the international bodies, the press, the public. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a citizen, a parliamentarian, an environmental expert, an international official, a journalist, and a judge all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the government or the proponent pushes back. In the Seychelles, the campaign with the better-documented case — above all the clearest proof of the threat to the protected place and the approval that can be withheld — is very often the one that turns the parliament and stops a project, as the opponents of Assumption did. A well-kept record matters all the more in a fight that must move quickly from the street to the chamber, for the case a parliamentarian makes in a ratification debate, or a lawyer makes in court, or an international body weighs, must be backed by documents that withstand scrutiny. When a campaign spans citizens, environmental organisations, the guardians of protected places, and sympathetic members of the Assembly, a shared and reliable file — the agreement, the approvals it needs, the protected status, the harm, the flaws in the process, all dated and sourced — is what lets each of them speak accurately and with one voice, and what stops the government or the proponent from picking the campaign apart on a careless claim. The opponents of the Assumption base could carry a consistent, documented case from the public meeting to the floor of the Assembly; a campaign should build that shared record from the very start.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE PUBLIC COALITION

Evidence does not win on its own. A mobilised public and a broad coalition do — and in the Seychelles, Assumption proves that a small nation's public, protesting, together with a parliament that will not ratify, can stop even a signed project. A campaign's strength here is that mobilisation and that breadth: a public roused across a small nation, and a coalition wide enough to reach the parliament.

Phase 1: The Core and the Cause

Start with a committed core rooted in the **environmental organisations and concerned citizens** — because in the Seychelles the protected place and the public are the strongest ground. Assign roles — documentation, the environmental case, the parliamentary liaison, the international outreach, media, and coalition. Agree on the goal — the approval withheld, the place protected, the project stopped — and on what the public will accept. Draw on the nation's pride in its world-renowned protected places and the power of a small nation's mobilised public.

Phase 2: The Broad Public Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **environmental organisations** and the **managers of the protected places**, who bring the expertise and the standing, as the guardians of Aldabra's environment did; **concerned citizens and the wider public**, whose protests a small nation registers directly, as the Assumption protests were; sympathetic voices across the **political spectrum** and in the **Assembly**, welcomed on the merits, because the parliament is the decisive arena; and, distinctively, the **international dimension** — the World Heritage and international bodies whose concern adds weight. Reach the **press**, at home and abroad. The Assumption campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — citizens, environmental organisations, parliamentarians, and international concern — which is precisely the spread a Seychellois campaign of this kind needs. The reach into the parliament deserves particular emphasis, because in the Seychelles it is where a campaign's breadth is finally tested. It is not enough to rouse the public and the environmental world; the case must be carried into the National Assembly and made to the members whose votes decide, in terms they can act on — the

threat to a treasured place, the flaws in the process, the weight of public feeling, the public interest against the project. Sympathetic members must be equipped with the evidence and the arguments to make the case in the chamber, and wavering members must be shown the strength and the seriousness of the public behind it. At Assumption, the opposition that held the Assembly became the decisive channel through which the public's alarm became a refusal to ratify; a campaign should build its bridge to the parliament deliberately and early, for that is where a Seychellois fight of this kind is often won.

A worked coalition example. Facing a project threatening a protected place, the environmental organisations and the place's managers supply the case; citizens and the public bring the protests; sympathetic parliamentarians carry it into the Assembly; and the international bodies add the global eye. No single group could carry it; together they cover the place, the public, the parliament, and the world — the model Assumption built.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, or of division. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — a protest, an organisation joining, a parliamentarian declaring, an international body's concern, a delay. Keep the coalition broad, and guard against the **discouragement, the pressure, and the diplomatic reassurance** that a signed deal will proceed. The distinctive danger is believing a signed agreement cannot be undone; the distinctive strength is a coalition that keeps the public mobilised and the parliament firm until the approval is withheld — as the opponents of Assumption did.

Phase 4: The Public and the Parliament

Here is the Seychelles' distinctive strength, on two levels. First, the **public: mobilise the public and protest**, because a small nation's public is felt directly by its leaders, as the Assumption protests were. Second, and decisively, the **parliament: bring the case to the National Assembly**, and press it to **withhold the approval or ratification** the project needs, as the Assembly withheld ratification of the Assumption agreement. Keep it **broad, public, and focused on the parliament**, because in the Seychelles it is the mobilised public and the parliament that will not ratify, more than any single lever, that stops a signed project — as they stopped Assumption.

STEP 4: LEGAL & DEMOCRATIC CHALLENGES — THE APPROVALS, THE PARLIAMENT, AND THE INTERNATIONAL BODIES

The Seychelles' approval processes, its parliament, its courts, and — distinctively — the international bodies are a real toolkit. You do not need to win at once: an objection on the record, an approval delayed, a parliamentary refusal, an international body's concern, a delay while you build the public — each is a real gain. Engage lawyers and the organisations early — but understand the tools.

The Approvals and the Environment

The first lever is the **approval process**. A project that threatens a protected place must, as a rule, clear **environmental approvals**, and these are open to **objection** — marshal the threat to the protected place, and build the record. Where a protected place is at risk, the environmental objection is both a legal step and the heart of the public case.

The Parliament and the Ratification

The second lever, and the decisive one at Assumption, is the **parliament**. Many agreements and major projects need the **National Assembly's ratification or approval**, and a parliament that **refuses** can stop a project outright, as the Assembly's refusal stopped the Assumption base. Identify whether the project needs the Assembly's assent, bring the case to the parliamentarians, and press them to withhold it — and understand that, in a small democracy, the **make-up of the Assembly** is itself part of the fight, decided at the ballot box. It is worth being clear-eyed about what this means in practice, because it shapes the whole strategy. Where the numbers in the Assembly favour refusal — as they did at Assumption, with the opposition in the majority — the campaign's task is to hold and harden that refusal, arming its parliamentary allies and keeping the public visibly behind them. Where the numbers favour the government, the ratification may well pass however strong the public feeling, and the campaign must then fight on other ground — the environmental objection, the courts, the international bodies, the pressure of publicity — while recognising that the composition of the parliament, and therefore the availability of the decisive lever, will ultimately be settled at the ballot

box. This is the honest arithmetic of a small democracy: the parliament is the most powerful lever, but it is one the electorate, not the campaign alone, finally controls.

The International Bodies and the Courts

The third lever is the **international bodies and the courts**. Where a **World Heritage site or a protected place** is threatened, the **World Heritage and international bodies** can be alerted, and their concern brings a global eye and real weight, as UNESCO's concern over Aldabra did; and the **courts** can be asked to enforce the environmental law. Use the international bodies to raise the profile and the stakes, and the courts where the law is breached. A word, too, on the courts as a distinct front: where an environmental approval is granted in breach of the law, or a protected area's status is disregarded, the courts can be asked to review and halt the decision, and even the prospect of litigation can give a government pause and a proponent doubt. The court route is slower and less certain than a parliamentary refusal, and it turns on the strength of the legal flaw rather than the weight of public feeling; but it is a real lever where the law has been broken, and it can hold a project while the public and parliamentary pressure build. A campaign should keep the legal option in view from the start, engaging lawyers early to assess whether the approvals and the process afford a genuine ground, so that if the parliamentary door is closed the judicial one may still be open. The international dimension deserves a word of precision, because a threat to a World Heritage site engages a global framework a campaign can turn to real advantage. Where a project imperils a listed site, or a site adjacent to a listed one, the World Heritage authorities and the wider conservation bodies can be formally alerted, and their expressions of concern carry a weight out of proportion to their formal power: they signal to the government that the nation's international standing and the status of a prized site are at stake, they lend the domestic campaign authority and visibility, and they draw international press. At Assumption, the concern voiced over the proximity of the works to Aldabra placed the matter on a world stage. A campaign should therefore alert the international bodies early and precisely, both for the pressure they apply and for the credibility and reach they lend the fight at home.

Where to Turn and With Whom

The environmental objections go through the **approval authorities**; the ratification through the **National Assembly**; the international concern through the **World Heritage and international bodies**; the legal challenge through the **courts**. Get help early: the Seychelles' environmental organisations, the managers of its protected places, its parliamentarians, and its lawyers know the approvals, the parliament, and the international frameworks. Help engaged early is worth far more than help sought after, and in the Seychelles the strongest strategy marries the **environmental objection and the international attention** to the **public mobilisation and the parliamentary refusal**, so that a project threatening a protected place is objected to, exposed to the world, protested against, and denied the approval it needs — as Assumption was.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a parliamentarian, a court, an international body, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a project would build near a pristine World Heritage atoll under an agreement that needs the Assembly's ratification. That one fact becomes:

- **A parliamentary argument:** the Assembly should withhold the ratification the project needs — the case that stops it.
- **An environmental argument:** a World Heritage atoll and its species are at risk — the case that rouses the nation and the world.
- **A public-interest argument:** the public interest — the environment, the sovereignty, the transparency — weighs against it — the case for the parliament and the public.
- **An international argument:** a World Heritage site is threatened — the case for UNESCO and the international bodies.
- **A transparency argument:** the agreement was made without proper openness — the case that erodes its legitimacy.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in the Seychelles the arguments that most often decide things are the **parliamentary** one, because it withholds the approval, and the **environmental** one, because a threatened protected place rouses the nation and the world. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the record and a claim made to a parliamentarian or a court can be proven;

consistency across audiences is itself persuasive. And be honest about mixed motives: where both environment and sovereignty drive a campaign, name both truthfully rather than dressing one as the other.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The parliamentarians respond to the public feeling, the protected place, the public interest, and their own power to withhold approval.

The courts want the environmental law and the process framed precisely, with the documents that prove the breach.

The international bodies want the threat to a World Heritage site or protected place framed against the international frameworks.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a pristine atoll at risk, a deal the public never saw, a parliament that may refuse.

The public needs the argument clear and stirring: our world-famous wild place, and a deal we never agreed to. The public argument, though it moves people most, must stay anchored to the documented facts if it is to serve the other fronts as well. The peril of a beloved, world-famous place and the affront of a deal made without the public's knowledge rouse a nation rightly; but the same facts, stated precisely — the protected status, the specific harm, the actual terms and process of the agreement — are also what the parliament, the courts, and the international bodies require. A campaign that lets the public argument drift into exaggeration hands the government and the proponent an easy rebuttal and weakens the case built on the same ground. Keep the public argument vivid but true, so that the story that moves the public and the evidence that moves a parliamentarian or a court are one and the same, drawn from a single reliable record.

The environmental world responds to the threat to protected species, habitats, and a World Heritage site. This environmental case is not a supplement to the campaign but part of its core, because in the Seychelles the peril of a protected place is what gives the whole fight its moral force and its national and international reach. The organisations that manage the protected places, and the scientists who know their species and habitats, can testify with authority to what a site holds and what a project would harm, and their evidence both strengthens any legal or international step and anchors the public argument in fact rather than sentiment. The Seychelles' environmental bodies and the guardians of its great protected places carry exactly this authority; a campaign should enlist them early and lean on their evidence throughout, so that the threat to the place is established beyond dispute.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in the Seychelles, where a world-renowned protected place is a source of national pride and a hidden deal is a story, coverage that carries the threat to the place and the public's exclusion is among the most powerful levers of all. Coverage mobilises the public, pressures the parliament, and draws the international eye. Assumption became a national and international story in large part through the press and the public attention the campaign drew — the leaked agreement, the protests, the threat to Aldabra.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the place and the process. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a foreign base would be built beside our World Heritage atoll under a deal the public never saw, and the parliament may refuse it" is — the kind of story that made Assumption a national and international cause. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the threat to the protected place, the hidden process, the approval the project needs — and offer the wonder of the place and a human voice: an image of the atoll and its tortoises, a citizen, a parliamentarian. In the Seychelles the story of a threatened world-famous place, and a deal the public never agreed to, is one the nation and the world respond to.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local voices and the public** first. Then the **national outlets** — because a threatened protected place and a hidden deal are national concerns, and national opinion moves the parliament, as it did over Assumption. Then, distinctively, the **international ring** — the international press and the World Heritage world — because a threat to a World Heritage site is a global story and a global lever. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national and international rings are both decisive** here.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the deal, the threat to the place, the hidden process, the protests, the international concern, the parliamentary refusal — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and the world. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and honest about motives; the government and the proponent will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, place-and-process-centred campaign is what sustains a national and international cause. Verified, specific, place-centred, honest, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped stop a base.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the government, the parliament, the approval authorities, the international bodies, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the threat to the place, the approval that can be withheld, and the public interest.

8A. Request for Information

To: the relevant ministry / authority **Subject:** Request for information on [project]

We, [community/organisation], request the **project details, the agreement, the approvals it needs, and the environmental assessment** for [project] at [place]. This affects a protected place and the public interest, and we are entitled to the record. Please provide the documents.

8B. Objection in the Approval Process

To: the environmental / approval authority **Subject:** Objection to [project] at [protected place]

We, [community/organisation], object to [project] at [place], which threatens [a World Heritage site / a protected area / a pristine place]. The **harm** to the protected place and its species is severe, and the **public interest** weighs against it. We ask that the approval be **refused** and the place protected.

8C. Submission to the National Assembly

To: the members of the National Assembly **Subject:** Please withhold approval of [project / agreement]

We, [community/organisation], urge the Assembly to **withhold its ratification / approval** of [project / agreement]. It threatens [a World Heritage site / a protected place], was made [without proper openness], and runs against the public interest. As the Assembly withheld ratification of the Assumption agreement, we ask you to withhold it here.

8D. Alert to the International Bodies

To: the World Heritage Centre / relevant international body **Subject:** Threat to [World Heritage site / protected place], Seychelles

We, [community/organisation], alert you to a threat to [site], a [World Heritage site / protected place]: [project] would [harm]. We ask that you take note of the concern and examine the threat, as the concern over Aldabra was noted.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Organisation

To: an environmental organisation / lawyer **Subject:** [Project] at [protected place] — the place, the approval, the process

We are opposing [project] at [place]. We attach the agreement, the approvals, and our evidence, and seek advice on **the environmental objection, the parliamentary approval, and the international route**. Please advise on the strongest steps and the deadlines.

8F. Approach to Parliamentarians

To: [parliamentarians] **Subject:** Stand with us to protect [place]

We write to the representatives of a nation proud of its protected places. We ask you to **stand against [project]** — which threatens [place] — and to **withhold the approval it needs**. This concerns the environment, the public interest, and the nation's pride; help us protect it.

8G. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the place / the project / the deal]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a national — and international — story, with a clear hook: [documents] show [finding — e.g. "a project would threaten our World Heritage atoll under a deal the public never saw, and the parliament may refuse it"]. It echoes Assumption. I can share the file and connect you with a citizen and an expert. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Coalition] will protect [place]

We, [coalition], oppose [project], which would threaten [place], one of our protected treasures. As the opponents of the Assumption base mobilised the public, drew the world's eye to a threatened atoll, and won a parliament that would not ratify, we will mobilise, draw the world's eye, and press our Assembly to withhold its approval. We will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of an objection, a submission to the Assembly, or an alert to an international body is itself evidence, and exactly what the parliament, the international bodies, and the nation will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the threat to the place, the approval that can be withheld, and the public interest; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the organisations, the parliamentarians, the international bodies, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the result, becomes part of your record, and in the Seychelles that record feeds the levers that matter most: the protected place, the public, the international eye, and the democratic and parliamentary process that stopped a base.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real work to stop a destructive project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

1. Establish the threat and the approval. Show the threat to the protected place, and find out what approval the project needs (Step 1, 8A).

2. Mobilise the public. Rouse the public around the threatened place (Step 3, 8H).

3. Bring it to the parliament. Urge the Assembly to withhold the approval the project needs (8C, 8F).

4. Alert the international bodies. Bring the threat to a protected place to the world's attention (8D).

5. Object in the approval process. Lodge the environmental objection (8B).

6. Reach the press — national and international. Take the story out (8G).

7. Keep it up, and win the electoral argument. Sustain the public and remember that the parliament's make-up is decided at the ballot box.

Do only the first three and you will have established the threat, mobilised the public, and brought it to the parliament — the foundation of a Seychellois defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: establish the threat and the approval, mobilise the public, bring it to the parliament. A note for the resource-poor campaign in particular: in the Seychelles the most powerful levers are, fortunately, not the most expensive. Mobilising a small nation's public, alerting the international bodies to a threatened World Heritage place, and persuading members of a small Assembly to withhold an approval cost mainly time, clarity, and persistence rather than money. What they require is a rigorous, well-documented case and the resolve to carry it from the street to the chamber and keep it there. A modest campaign that establishes the threat and the approval, rouses the public, and reaches the parliament has already assembled the essential machinery that stopped the Assumption base; everything else strengthens it, but this is the core

within reach of even a small and poorly funded group.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The Seychelles' system, as a small democracy with an active civil society, courts, a free press, world-renowned protected places, and a parliament whose approval many projects need, is by many measures open to a community opposing a destructive project — but it is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor grow discouraged.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. **Powerful development, tourism, and foreign interests** press on a small nation's land and waters. **A government's determination** to sign a deal carries weight, and a government that **controls the parliament** can deny you the decisive lever. **Small size** can mean pressure and closeness among the powerful. And a signed agreement can be defended with **diplomatic reassurance** that it will proceed. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes a signed deal cannot be undone, or that overlooks the parliament and the ballot box, will be disappointed — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy is to defend the protected place, mobilise the public, draw the international eye, and turn the democratic and parliamentary process against it.

What Still Works — And Some Is Strong

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, the Seychelles' levers are real, and some are strong.

A protected place still rouses the nation and the world. A threat to a World Heritage site is a national and international cause.

A mobilised public is still felt directly. In a small nation, protests reach the leaders.

A parliament that refuses still stops a project. Where an approval is needed, an Assembly that withholds it is decisive.

The international eye still adds weight. The World Heritage bodies bring a global spotlight.

The ballot box still shapes the parliament. In a small democracy, elections decide whether the decisive lever is in reach.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for the Seychelles is realistic and clear-eyed: the decisive lever may need a willing parliament, the motives may be mixed, and the outcome may be nuanced — but the protected place, the public, the international eye, and the democratic and parliamentary process give a community real, and sometimes strong, levers, and stopping a signed project by protecting a place and turning a parliament is a real victory. So diagnose your fight honestly: defend the **protected place**; mobilise the **public**; draw the **international eye**; turn the **democratic and parliamentary process** against it; and, where you must, **win the electoral argument** that shapes the parliament. Do not assume a signed deal cannot be undone; the Assumption base was stopped because a mobilised public and a parliament that would not ratify refused to let it proceed.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

The Seychelles has had real concerns about opaque deals and the closeness of powerful interests to power, so this section matters. When a project is driven not by the public interest but by a hidden deal, or by private or foreign interests, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of a hidden or captured deal. An **agreement kept from the public**, emerging only by leak, as the Assumption pacts did; a **project that threatens a protected place** for private or foreign benefit; an **opaque process**

without proper consultation or parliamentary scrutiny; **close ties** between the proponent, the officials, and the powerful; and **benefits to the few or to outside interests** while the nation loses a protected place or a measure of its sovereignty. Trace the deal and the process: how it was made, who benefits, and whether the public and the parliament were properly involved. In the Seychelles, a hidden deal threatening a protected place is worth examining for the interests behind it.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the government** can make opaque deals or be pressured by powerful interests. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **National Assembly**, especially when the opposition holds it, as it held the Assumption ratification; the **courts**; the **international bodies**, beyond national reach; the **environmental organisations and the managers of protected places**; the **free press**; and, above all, the **mobilised public**. Distinctively, the parliament and the international bodies are powerful checks beyond a government's control, and a mobilised public in a small nation is felt directly. Your task is to document the hidden deal and the threat, and bring them to the parliament, the international bodies, the press, and the public.

What to Do

Do not assume a hidden or captured deal cannot be undone. Instead, **document it precisely** — the hidden agreement, the threat to the place, the interest served — and take it to the forces that can act: the **National Assembly**; the **courts**; the **international bodies**; the **press**; and the **public**. Pair the exposure with the threat to the protected place, so the hidden deal and the loss of a treasure arrive together. In the Seychelles, exposing a hidden deal that threatens a protected place, and taking it to the parliament and the public, is often the way to stop it — as the exposure of the Assumption agreement and the threat to Aldabra helped turn the public and the parliament against it. Do this with care, for exposing the powerful invites pushback.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in the Seychelles turns on the protected place, the public, the international eye, and the democratic and parliamentary process.

Early (Weeks 0-8): The Threat, the Public, and the Parliament

Pin down the project and the approvals it needs (Step 1); document the **threat to the place and the process** (Step 2). Mobilise the **public** and build the coalition fast (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the information** (8A); **object in the approval process** (8B); **bring it to the Assembly** (8C, 8F); **alert the international bodies** (8D); and reach **organisations and lawyers** early (8E). This phase lays the foundation, and in the Seychelles the threat established, the public mobilised, and the parliament engaged here are what win.

Middle (Months): Mobilise, Expose, and Press the Parliament

Sustain the public and the coalition (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Press the **environmental objection and the international attention**, and, decisively, press the **parliament to withhold the approval** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat, national and international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — the parliamentary case before a ratification vote, the international alert before approval — because those chances are most powerful early.

Later (Months): The Refusal, the Stop, and Vigilance

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **approval withheld, the project stopped, the place protected** — and then stay vigilant, because, as the Seychelles shows, a deal may linger in diplomatic language and a proponent may return. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a parliament's refusal that stops a project, as at Assumption. Sometimes it is a project quietly shelved, as at Assumption. Both, where they protect the place, are victories worth the fight — even if a foreign presence does not vanish overnight.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8
MONTHS
LATER

Establish threat + approval needed | Mobilise the public | Object | Bring it to the Assembly
Sustain the public | Environmental objection + international attention | Press the parliament | Media
Approval withheld / project stopped | Stay vigilant -- deals linger, proponents return

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Seychelles gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. A **pristine, protected place** — a World Heritage site, a wild atoll — rouses the nation and the world. **Public mobilisation** — in a small nation where protests reach the leaders directly — is a genuine force. The **international eye** — the World Heritage and international bodies — brings a global spotlight and real weight. And, decisively, the **democratic and parliamentary process** — a National Assembly whose approval a project needs and which can refuse — can stop a project outright. These are the tools that stopped the Assumption base.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The decisive lever — a parliament that would not ratify — depended on an **opposition majority**, so where a government controls the Assembly the ballot box becomes part of the fight. The opposition had **mixed motives** — genuine environmental protection of a World Heritage atoll, and also national sovereignty and geopolitics — and honesty requires naming both. And the outcome was **nuanced** — the base was blocked and the agreement in time declared dead, but a foreign presence did not vanish at once and diplomatic language lingered. No guide should pretend these away; in the Seychelles, the art is to defend the protected place, mobilise the public, draw the international eye, turn the parliament, win the electoral argument where you must, and keep fighting, because stopping a signed project by protecting a place and turning a parliament is a real victory.

So the realistic promise is this: **defend the protected place; mobilise the public; draw the international eye; turn the democratic and parliamentary process against it — winning the electoral argument where you must — running all of it together.** Do that, and where a project threatens a protected place and needs an approval a parliament can withhold, you can stop it, as the opponents of Assumption did; where no approval can be withheld or a government controls the parliament, you can still win delay, a record, the international eye, and the case made — and shape the parliament at the next election. Do it as they did — a mobilised public and a parliament that would not ratify.

A last word on the public and the parliament. The Seychelles' lesson is that a mobilised public — that defends a pristine, protected place and draws the world's eye — together with a parliament that will not grant the approval a project needs, can stop even a signed project; but that the decisive lever may need a willing parliament, that motives may be mixed, and that a foreign or private interest may linger. The powerful count on your believing the deal is signed and cannot be undone, or on your overlooking the parliament and the ballot box. Their advantage is the determination to build, the closeness of interests, and the reassurance that a deal will proceed. Yours is the protected place, the mobilised public, the international eye, the parliament that can refuse, the ballot box that shapes it, and the proven fact that the opponents of the Assumption base stopped it. Play to that — and where you must, win the vote. Keep the record and the proof of the threat and the approval needed, keep the public mobilised, draw the world's eye, press the parliament, and treat every protest, every parliamentarian who declares, every international body that takes note, and every approval withheld as a stone in a wall around a protected place.

The tools are here, and Assumption itself proved them, honestly and with its nuances: a foreign-backed military base to be built beside one of the world's great atolls, a World Heritage treasure, under a signed agreement — opposed by Seychellois citizens and environmental organisations out of genuine fear for the pristine place and concern for the nation's sovereignty, protested in the streets, noted with concern by the World Heritage authorities, and, decisively, refused ratification by a National Assembly the opposition held, so that the government could not carry it through; a base not built, an agreement in time declared dead, and the nation choosing to build its own, smaller facility instead. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the value of the protected place, the mobilisation of the public, the eye of the world, and the will of a parliament that can refuse — and those a determined public can summon. Begin today, begin with the threat and the public and the parliament, and build from there. Communities before you have stopped a signed project — a base refused, a World Heritage atoll defended, a parliament that would not ratify. What the opponents of the Assumption base did can be done again. So can yours.